What's the Password Again?

Distributed Software and Cooperatives

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3. Future Visioning / Planning
    - How *could* we use software?
    - What needs to be done? How can we help to make co-ops more efficient and effective?

Overview of Technologies

What is Technology?



What is Technology?

"technology includes all tools, machines, utensils, weapons, instruments, housing, clothing, communicating and transporting devices and the skills by which we produce and use them" – Read Bain, sociologist

Cooperative Technology - What is it?

- signage



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Cooperative Technology - What is it?

- signage
- dinner bell
- filing cabinet
- group messaging apps
- meeting rules / Robert's Rules of Order



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- Scheduling, voting (when not all parties can be in the same place)

Most Important Takeaway

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"the revolution will not be televised..." or on your smartphone

Discussion

What technologies does your co-op use for **decisionmaking**, **document sharing**, and **bookkeeping**?

When do these work well, and when are they frustrating?

Remember, technologies include things like rules for running meetings, written notes, signs, as well as computerized technologies.

Free and Open Source Software

Why Care About Open Source?

```
def my_program(input):
    calculate the thing
    output "useful information"
    save "file_for_later.txt"
```



```
0001010101010101
1010101010111110
0101010101011111
```

“Free and Open Source Software” Principles

“the freedom to use, study, copy, modify, and redistribute computer software”

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Open source software is continually improved - bugs can be fixed by anyone, not just developers working for company

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- autonomy and independence
  - "Co-operatives are autonomous, self-help organizations controlled by their members. If they enter into agreements with other organizations. . . they do so on terms that ensure democratic control by their members and maintain their co-operative autonomy."

Case Study: Quickbooks Online

From Intuit's Terms of Service:

"Note that we may modify the **amount of storage space** you have through the Services and the **number of times** (and the maximum duration for which) you may access the Services in a given period of time... Your continued use of the Services will constitute your acceptance of and agreement to such changes."

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What if Intuit goes out of business? Or decides to double prices? Or their servers are hacked and data is stolen/deleted? Users have no recourse.

convenience vs. control

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"just call the landlord" vs. self-management

Decentralized Software

Decentralized Software

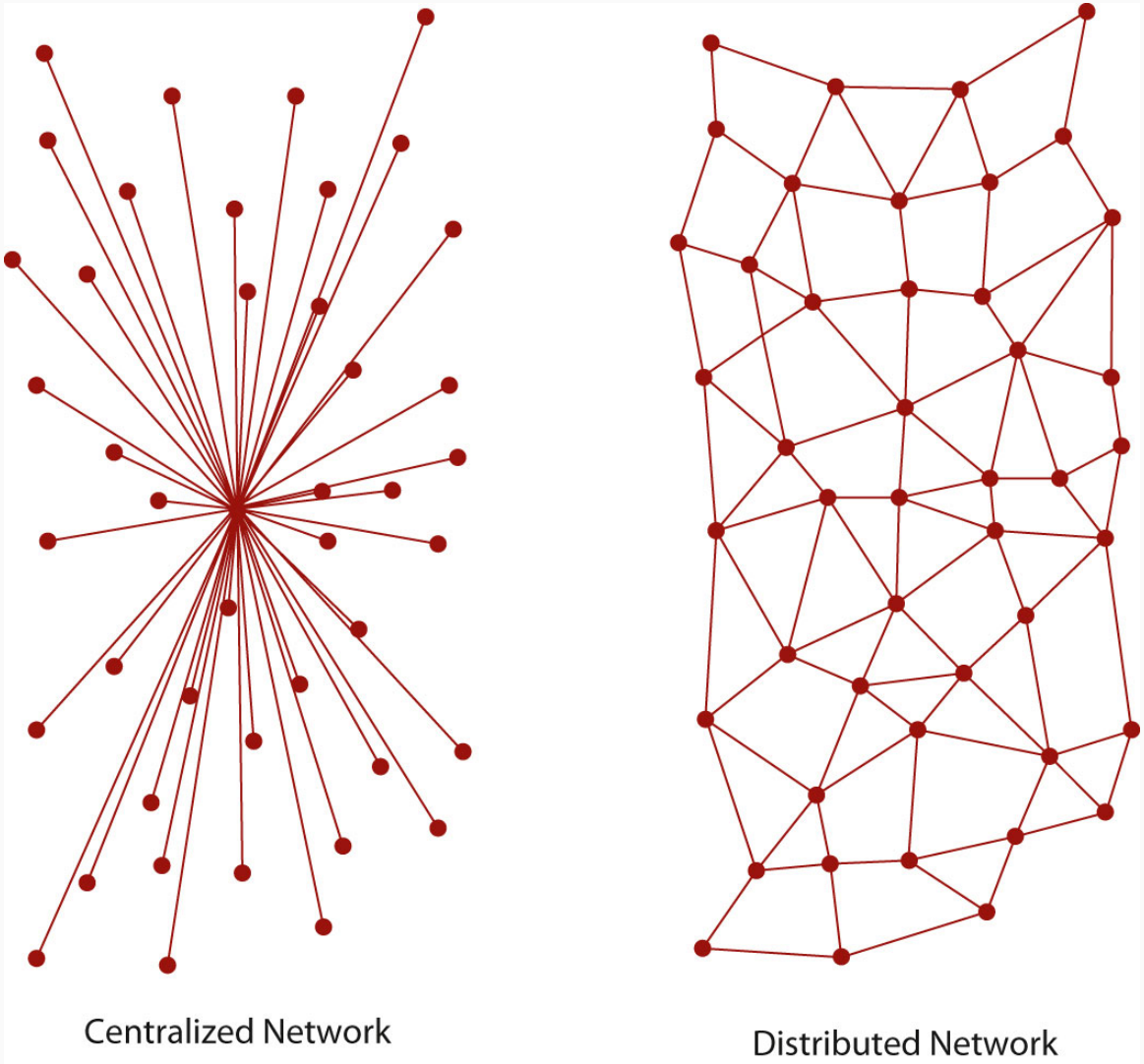


Figure 1: Figure from *Understanding Media and Culture: An Introduction to Mass Communication*

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Can use for documents, distributed ledgers (everyone keeps track of everyone's transactions), etc

Examples of Co-op Software and Alternatives

Google Docs

Each document is “owned” by one Google account. This account can change sharing settings, delete the document, etc. Google can lock people out of docs if they violate Terms of Service.

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Best Practices:

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- Save local backups / use Chrome "offline" extension

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Can use GitHub (semi-centralized solution) for better interfaces, hosting wikis, etc.

Alternative: wikis



Not logged in Talk Contributions Create account Log in

Article Talk | Read Edit View history | Search Wikipedia

WIKIPEDIA
The Free Encyclopedia

Main page
Contents
Featured content
Current events
Random article
Donate to Wikipedia
Wikipedia store

Interaction

Help
About Wikipedia
Community portal
Recent changes
Contact page

Tools

What links here
Related changes

LocalWiki

From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

LocalWiki is a collaborative project that aims to collect and open the world's local knowledge. The LocalWiki project was founded by DavisWiki creators Mike Ivanov and Philip Neustrom[1] and is a 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization[2] based in San Francisco, California.[3] LocalWiki is both the name of the project and the software that runs the project's websites.

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3 Notable LocalWiki communities
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5 References
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LocalWiki

localwiki

Original author(s)	*Michael Ivanov, Philip Neustrom*
Developer(s)	LocalWiki
Stable release	v0.5.5
Preview release	Master
Development status	Active
Written in	Python
Website	LocalWiki

Loomio

- centralized tool for decentralized organizations
- open source, co-op run
- integrated collection of tools for voting on proposals, scheduling meetings, polling groups

loomio.org



Platform Co-op

Resource for starting and finding co-ops with digital platforms (ride sharing, journalism, finance, data management, etc)

platform.coop

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- Basic idea behind bitcoin (though 96% of bitcoin is owned by 4% of the network - not exactly decentralized)
- Ideas could be useful for tracking internal transactions in co-ops (not just money: hours worked, task assignments, etc)

A Plea

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consider creating space in your organizations for dedicated "software coordinators"

Discussion

What do we want computers to do for us? What can "software coordinators" do for co-ops?

What are the **obstacles** to changing technologies?

Which of these obstacles are **actionable**?